Chief, not of my Regiment or of the Infantry but of the entire Indian Army. That each and every Arm and Service had an important role to play and that there would be no favouritism or parochialism—no 'lanyard culture'—as it is known, i.e. favouring persons from your own Regiment or region. Everyone would be judged solely on merit and professional contribution. I tried to impress upon all to concentrate more on 'Substance' than 'Style', to cut out the bullshit, frills and other excesses like the gifting culture and bouquets at airports/helipads. These were issues that were close to my heart and which I had been implementing in my zone of influence right from my Brigade Commander days. I also recapped the more common and long-standing issues, such as zero tolerance towards corruption and human rights violations. Lastly, I reiterated that we are all, from top to bottom, General to jawan, ambassadors of the Army and that our conduct should be above reproach. From the feedback that I received, the talk was much appreciated, especially the part about the 'no lanyard' culture, and now the onus was on me to walk the talk.

My first outstation visit was to Leh, the HQ of 14 Corps. Little was I to know then, of what was in store and that Leh would be the place I would visit the most in my tenure as Chief. I landed in Leh on 9 January 2020, and after a quick medical check-up at Timmy Hut, a small waiting area just outside the airport, I transferred to Advanced Light Helicopters (ALH) or choppers, for an aerial reconnaissance of the Siachen Glacier. We flew along the glacier, seeing the off-take points towards the Saltoro Ridge to the West on the route out, and the possible routes towards Daulat Beg Oldi (DBO) in Eastern Ladakh on the route in, landing at Kumar Post for a briefing and tea with the troops stationed there. Even with all the special clothing, we were chilled to the bone. The temperature at Kumar Post must

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